

Psalms 142

A Cry from the Cave

I cried unto the Lord with my voice... I poured out my complaint before him
KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 *I cried unto the LORD with my voice; with my voice unto the LORD did I make my supplication.*
- 2 *I poured out my complaint before him; I shewed before him my trouble.*
- 3 *When my spirit was overwhelmed within me, then thou knewest my path. In the way wherein I walked have they privily laid a snare for me.*
- 4 *I looked on my right hand, and beheld, but there was no man that would know me: refuge failed me; no man cared for my soul.*
- 5 *I cried unto thee, O LORD: I said, Thou art my refuge and my portion in the land of the living.*
- 6 *Attend unto my cry; for I am brought very low: deliver me from my persecutors; for they are stronger than I.*
- 7 *Bring my soul out of prison, that I may praise thy name: the righteous shall compass me about; for thou shalt deal bountifully with me.*

2 · CONTEXT

Titled a Maschil of David when he was in the cave, this psalm likely reflects his time hiding from Saul at Adullam or En-gedi—isolated, friendless, and surrounded by pursuers stronger than himself. It moves from raw complaint through the stark admission that no one cares for his soul, to a direct appeal naming God as his only refuge and portion. Henry reads it as a template for prayer offered from genuine isolation, where human support has entirely failed.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-3

David cries aloud to the Lord, pouring out his complaint and showing his trouble openly, precisely because his spirit is overwhelmed within him. The psalm opens with permission to be loud and specific in distress rather than composed.

Verse 4-5

Isolation is named starkly: looking to his right hand, David finds no one who truly knows him; refuge has failed, and no one cares for his soul. In that vacuum he cries directly to the Lord, calling Him his refuge and his portion in the land of the living—God filling exactly the space human support has left empty.

Verse 6-7

The plea intensifies: attend to my cry, for I am brought very low, deliver me from persecutors stronger than I am. The psalm closes in hope rather than despair: bring my soul out of this prison so I may praise your name, and the righteous will gather around me, for you will deal bountifully with me.

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

Prayer offered from genuine isolation—where human care has failed entirely—is not lesser or less faithful than prayer offered in community; it is exactly the kind of prayer this psalm models and validates. God is named directly as refuge and portion precisely in the gap left by absent human support, not as a consolation prize for lacking friends.

Application for life today.

If you currently feel that 'no man cares for my soul,' as verse 4 puts it, let this psalm give you permission to bring that isolation directly and specifically to God rather than minimizing it. Notice that David does not wait for community to return before praying with confidence—practice trusting God as your refuge even while human support remains absent. Hold onto verse 7's hope that isolation is not necessarily permanent; pray specifically for the righteous fellowship this psalm anticipates being restored.

5 · REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. Where in your life does verse 4's admission—'no man cared for my soul'—describe your current experience of isolation?

2. How does David's willingness to cry aloud and 'pour out his complaint' (vv. 1–2) model a kind of honest prayer you need permission to practice?

3. What would it look like to trust God specifically as your 'refuge' and 'portion' (v. 5) while still waiting for human community to be restored?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, *Commentary on the Whole Bible* (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).